# Digital Literacy

**Name:** Aradhya Negi
**Registration Number:** 25BOE10086
**Branch:** B.Tech Bioengineering
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Introduction As a newly appointed Student Digital Ambassador, my primary responsibility is to guide my peers in safely and professionally navigating the digital landscape. This project serves as a foundational Digital Literacy Portfolio, demonstrating the essential skills required for modern academic and professional success. Through a series of five distinct tasks, this portfolio explores critical themes ranging from the creation of professional online identities and the effective use of cloud collaboration tools, to the nuances of digital communication and the urgent need for cybercrime awareness. By actively building profiles, exploring platforms like GitHub and Kaggle, and analyzing real-world cybersecurity threats such as UPI fraud, this project not only establishes my personal digital footprint but also equips me with the practical knowledge to assist my batchmates in fostering secure, responsible, and impactful online habits.

**Task 1:**
For the first task of my Digital Literacy Portfolio, I chose to use Canva to design my awareness infographic. The platform provided an intuitive interface and a wide variety of elements that made the visual design process highly efficient.
My final design serves as a quick-reference guide for my batchmates, covering three critical aspects of digital literacy. First, it defines what digital literacy actually means in a modern academic context. Second, it highlights essential safe internet practices, specifically focusing on data security. Finally, it outlines the importance of maintaining a professional online presence, which is especially crucial for biotechnology students like myself who will soon be looking for research internships or lab placements.
One thing I found particularly interesting while making this infographic was the challenge of visual hierarchy. It was surprisingly difficult to condense broad concepts into bite-sized, easily digestible bullet points without losing the core message. Balancing the text-to-graphics ratio so that the document looked engaging rather than overwhelming required a lot of trial and error. Ultimately, this exercise reinforced that effective digital communication relies heavily on how accessibly information is presented to the audience.

**Task 2:**
For my digital portfolio, I established a professional presence on LinkedIn, GitHub, and Kaggle. I selected LinkedIn as my primary networking platform to build my industry identity, connect with academic peers, and eventually seek internships in the bioengineering sector. Over the next four years, I plan to actively update my education and project sections to reflect my academic milestones.
GitHub serves as my core technical repository. While it is traditionally used for software engineering, I intend to utilize it to document my computational biology projects, specifically hosting the Prolog code I am writing and version-controlling data models. Finally, I chose

Kaggle because of its strong focus on data science and machine learning. In modern biotechnology, analyzing large datasets is crucial. I plan to use Kaggle to access open-source datasets related to population genetics and cellular stress physiology, allowing me to practice my analytical skills on real-world biological data. Setting up these three platforms establishes a balanced digital footprint that bridges my interests in professional development, programming, and advanced academic research.

**Task 3:**
For Task 3, I explored both coding and cloud collaboration platforms, specifically focusing on HackerRank and Google Workspace. On HackerRank, I created an account and completed a beginner-level Python challenge. This provided a hands-on introduction to a competitive coding environment, which is highly relevant to my goal of integrating programming with biotechnology. Practicing coding on these platforms will help me develop the algorithmic thinking necessary for complex computational tasks, such as analyzing population genetics data or running biological simulations.
For the collaboration component, I utilized Google Forms to build a five-question "Digital Literacy Awareness Quiz." I designed it with a mix of multiple-choice and short-answer questions to effectively survey my peers. Generating the linked Google Sheet allowed me to see how response data is automatically collected and organized. Academically, mastering these Google Workspace tools is incredibly beneficial. Whether I am collecting survey data for a group presentation on AI ethics, organizing laboratory results for a stress physiology project, or collaborating with classmates on research, these platforms ensure that data management is efficient, secure, and easily accessible.

**Task 4:**
A classic example of poor digital communication causing a real problem is the dreaded "Reply All" disaster. Imagine a university administrator emails all students about a policy change. A student, intending to privately vent to a friend, accidentally hits "Reply All" and sends an unprofessional, angry complaint to the entire campus. This instantly damages the student's academic reputation, offends faculty, and clutters thousands of inboxes.
What could have been done differently? First, the student should have paused to process their emotions offline rather than reacting instantly. Second, they must always verify the recipient fields before typing. A safer approach is to draft sensitive messages in a separate document to prevent accidental sending, or simply discuss the frustration in person. This scenario highlights why taking a moment to review—a core tenet of digital etiquette—is absolutely critical.

**Task 5:**
While researching UPI fraud for this case study, what surprised me most was how heavily scammers rely on psychological manipulation rather than advanced computer hacking. They do not need to break into a bank's secure mainframe; they simply manufacture a sense of panic—like a fake urgent fee or a blocked account—to make intelligent college students bypass their own common sense and willingly hand over their UPI PINs in a rush. It is terrifying how effective social engineering can be. As a result of this research, the one major habit I am personally changing is my response time to "urgent" messages. Going forward, I will enforce a strict five-minute "pause and verify" rule before clicking any link or authorizing any payment, completely removing the emotional panic from the equation.

## Conclusion

Completing this Digital Literacy Portfolio has profoundly reshaped my understanding of online engagement. I have learned that a digital footprint is not merely a passive byproduct of internet use, but an active, curated asset that can significantly impact my academic and professional trajectory in biotechnology. From mastering visual communication tools to understanding the psychological tactics behind cybercrime, the project highlighted that digital literacy extends far beyond basic computer skills. It requires continuous vigilance, strategic personal branding, and thoughtful communication. Ultimately, this experience has transformed my approach from being a casual digital consumer to a responsible and proactive digital citizen.

## References


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